CASE STUDY

# A school canteen platform that took the allergen risk out of lunch

Allergen safety, meal pre-ordering and billing for an international school, built from scratch. Allergy incidents are now close to non-existent, and a daily process that needed 7+ staff runs with 2.

My role: product manager | 5 years in production | About 2,500 users | One school

## The problem

An international school served lunch through a manual process: spreadsheets and hundreds of physical tokens handed out and collected every day. It did not control the one thing that mattered most, students coming into contact with food allergens. That was a liability risk for the school, and no product on the market solved it.

## What I did

I was the school's IT manager, and I took ownership of the problem as product manager. I wrote the requirements from scratch, designed the application, sourced a remote team of four developers and drove the build from first line to go-live.

## Design decisions that came from watching the real environment

### Barcode readers, not cameras

Dedicated barcode readers at the serving counter. Camera scanning fails at volume once a queue of students builds up.

### Allergens as images

Serving staff see allergens as images, because many do not share a language with the students. Allergens are also filtered when a parent makes the reservation.

### A kitchen display you never touch

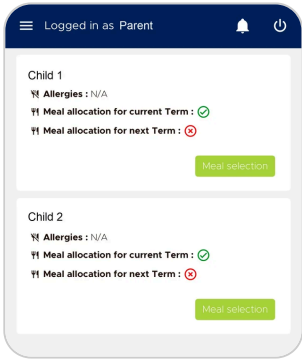
The kitchen tablet only displays, so staff keep their hands free. This was designed during COVID.

## What it looks like

Parents pre-order meals in a mobile app and pay online by card. Each child's allergies and meal allocation sit on one screen, so a mistake is hard to make and easy to see.

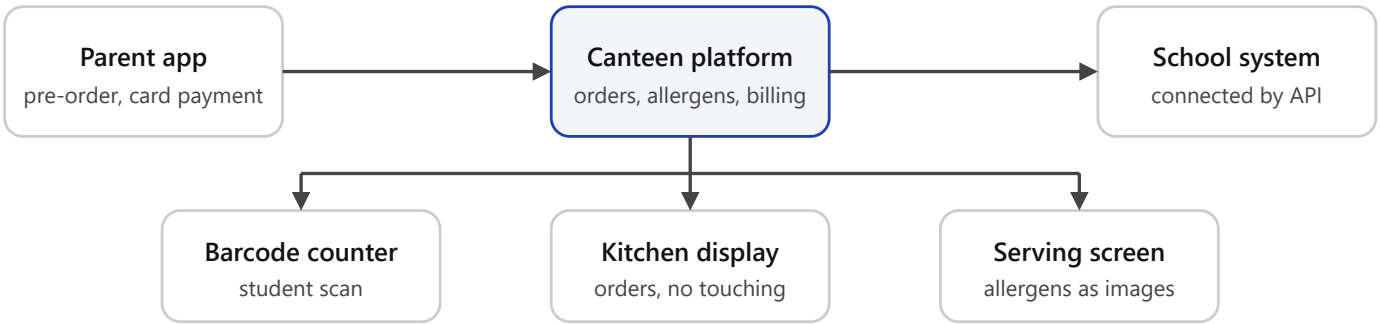
The allergen icons below are the ones the app uses: pictures instead of words.






Parent app home screen, with demo data.

## How it works



## The result

| Close to none | 7+ to 2 | About 2,500 |
| --- | --- | --- |
| allergy incidents at the point of service | staff needed each day for the meal process | users: students and their parents |

- ✓ Student safety was the point. The allergen risk at the point of service is effectively removed.
- ✓ The spreadsheets and hundreds of physical tokens are gone, and the process is faster and fully digital.

## Where it is now

The platform is being modernized with AI coding tools: .NET 4.5 to .NET 10 and a React upgrade across several major versions, with the interface and functions redesigned as part of it.

Terms: school canteen management, allergen management, mobile pre-ordering, barcode access, online card payments, API integration, .NET, React Native, legacy modernization.

**Mark Tenzer**, technical project manager and integration specialist. LinkedIn

Case study v0.2, 31 October 2026. Names and branding removed. No tracking and no outside scripts.